

Kennedy tailoring views for senators

Eases some GOP concerns on polio vaccine, abortion

By Sam Brodey and Jim Puzzanghera
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — The moment he arrived on Capitol Hill this week as President-elect Donald Trump’s nominee for health secretary, Robert F. Kennedy Jr. was confronted with perhaps the top task of his confirmation: papering over his decades-long record of controversy.

“I’m all for the polio vaccine,” said Kennedy, hounded by cameras and reporters, as he made his way to Florida Senator Rick Scott’s office on Monday morning for the first of a slew of meetings to try to secure the votes needed for confirmation. It was one of his only comments to reporters all week.

The fact that Kennedy needed to declare his support for the polio vaccine, one of the great medical advances of the 20th century, stems from a New York Times report that one of his top advisers had petitioned the Food and Drug Administration to revoke approval for the life-saving injection.

Kennedy himself has questioned the overall effectiveness of the polio vaccine and suggested on a podcast last year that it might have caused cancer “that killed many, many, many, many, many more people than polio ever did.” A 2002 study by the health arm of the National Academy of Sciences concluded there wasn’t enough evidence to “accept or reject a causal relationship” between a long-since-dis-

KENNEDY, Page A6

Avast, ye porch pirates — we need our booty

By Beth Teitell
GLOBE STAFF

The anxiety begins the moment an alert hits her phone. *Your package has been delivered.*

The notifications are meant to be helpful. But for Kim Collins, a disabled Central Square resident who lives on a fixed income on the 18th floor of a building with slow elevators and a cat that needs to be corralled before Collins can open her door, the updates are the start of a frantic race against time:

Who will reach her package first: Her? Or the thieves who materialize out of nowhere, saunter into her building’s vestibule, and brazenly grab what they please?

One time, they took the Chewy box with kitty litter. Another, they got her \$200 handbag, after she’d spent more than half a year saving for it.

“You feel like you are at war,” Collins said, “with an enemy you can’t see.”

These thieves, known as “porch pirates,” are by now a well-known phenomenon, but they have become ubiquitous as the age of delivered-to-your-front-door has overtaken us. And the idea that the thieves are right outside our homes — lurking, waiting, watching, swooping in, moments after the delivery person leaves, acting alone or as part of a ring, hats pulled low or as barefaced as the day they were born — has many residents feeling violated, on edge, angry.

PORCH PIRATES, Page A10

Fed cuts cautiously as inflation lingers

Rates are reduced for a third time this year, but only two set for 2025

By Jeanna Smialek
NEW YORK TIMES

Federal Reserve officials made their third and final rate cut of 2024 at their meeting on Wednesday. They also forecast two fewer rate reductions in 2025 than they had previously expected, as inflation lingers and the economy holds up.

The Fed has come a long way from just a few years ago:

In 2022, inflation was more than twice its current rate and many economists thought that the central bank’s decisions might cause economic pain — and even a recession — as it rapidly lifted interest rates to slow demand and wrestle price increases back under control.

That didn’t happen. The job market slowed without falling apart, and inflation cooled so

substantially that the Fed was able to begin cutting interest rates in September.

But the Fed is now entering a new phase in its journey toward an economic soft landing — a much more uncertain one.

Officials thought that it was clear that rates needed to come down notably from their 5.3 percent peak, and they have steadily lowered them to about 4.4 percent by making three back-to-back reductions. Policy makers do not want to cut rates so much that they reig-

nite the economy, though — and they have now arrived at a point where it is uncertain how much further rates should fall.

“Our policy stance is now significantly less restrictive,” Jerome Powell, the Fed chair, said during a news conference Wednesday. “We can therefore be more cautious as we consider further adjustments to our policy rate.”

“From here, it’s a new phase,” Powell later added. The Fed’s forecasts make

clear that central bankers are poised to slow rate cuts notably starting next year as stubborn inflation lingers — and Powell made it clear that the Fed wants to see further progress toward cooler inflation to cut interest rates at all.

Markets shuddered at that assessment, with the dollar soaring and stocks plummeting. The S&P 500 index fell nearly 3 percent, its worst tumble since August. The Dow Jones industrial average fell

RATES, Page A7

A SHOT IN THE DARK



STAN GROSSFELD/GLOBE STAFF

As the days get shorter and the cold closes in, Mt. Auburn Cemetery in Cambridge is featuring “Solstice: Reflections on Winter Light,” combining art and sound as well as light. The installations, created by Masary Studios, include “The Eclipse,” which brings a solar spectacle down to Earth through white light and a large black disc. The event runs through Saturday. **B1.**

‘People can try and undermine my credibility, whatever, but the reality is what I’ve been saying for all these years was true.’

NICOLE BELL-PEÑA, *who spent a decade on the street*

Women see vindication in report on Worcester police misbehavior

By Nick Stoico
GLOBE STAFF

WORCESTER — About two decades ago, Nicole Bell-Peña, then 24, left her home in Stoughton and came to Worcester seeking treatment for an opioid addiction. At a homeless shelter, she met a man who introduced her to crack cocaine, she said.

Bell-Peña spent the next 10 years on the street, selling sex to support her addiction. The man she met in the shelter trafficked her, she said, but she continued in prostitution on her own after he went to jail.

She was arrested some 30 times in those years, including once by a Worcester police officer who of-

► Hundreds turn out for community meeting. **B1.**

ferred to keep her out of jail if she had sex with him, she said. Bell-Peña engaged in sex with him “multiple times” between about 2008 and 2014, when she was arrested again and sent to jail, she said.

“When I got out, I really felt like if I had to engage in one more sex act with a sex buyer, I was going to kill him or myself,” she said recently.

Last week, the Justice Department issued a scathing report on the Worcester Police Department, finding that officers engaged in a “pattern or practice” of sexual contact with women suspected of prostitution. It was the first time the department had issued such a finding after a civil rights probe of a police depart-



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Nicole Bell-Peña started the sex-trafficking survivor organization Safe Exit Initiative.

ment, and for Bell-Peña and other women who spoke with investigators, it was long overdue.

“People can try and undermine my credibility, whatever, but the reality is what I’ve been saying for all these years was true,” she said. “I want to commend all the survivors that came forward because it’s incredibly scary. The DOJ worked incredibly hard to build trust with a marginalized group of people so

WORCESTER, Page A10

Reenacting the Battle of Bunker Hill — in Gloucester

Charlestown deemed too congested for 250th

By Brian MacQuarrie
GLOBE STAFF

When the 250th anniversary of the American Revolution kicks off next year, the bloody Battle of Bunker Hill will be fought again — but this time in Gloucester. Not once, but twice.

With the Charlestown battlefield off-limits because of urban congestion and National Park Service restrictions, more than 700 reenactors from around the world, including Britain, will use Stage Fort Park on the Gloucester waterfront for a weekend commemoration June 21 to 22.

The decision to use Gloucester was two years in the making, as organizers scouted other Massachusetts locales that could provide a suitable hill, close to the water, with plenty of room to maneuver. In 1975, a smaller reenactment was held on Bunker Hill to mark the 200th anniversary, but that event was somewhat less than a big-stage, vivid reimagining of the first pitched battle of the Revolution — technically, a hard-won British victory, but also a monumental morale boost for the Colonials.

“We want to give the general public a chance

BUNKER HILL, Page A7

BPS Superintendent Mary Skipper has proposed another revision to the admissions system for exam schools. **B1.**

MIT paid \$1.3 million for landscape artwork by Maya Lin but few in Kendall Square know it’s there. **D1.**

A bipartisan spending deal to avert a shutdown was on life support after Donald Trump condemned it. **A2.**

It’s time for Patriots offensive coordinator Alex Van Pelt to go, writes columnist Christopher L. Gasper. **C1.**



Taking the fall

Thursday: Breezy, cooler. High 42-47. Low 29-34.

Friday: Cloudy and cold. High 35-40. Low 26-31.

Comics and Weather, D5-6. Obituaries, C9.

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